

Hyderabad with another girl in sight.

The Siddiquis' first response was scorn with Ayesha's father Mohammed Ahmed Siddiqui saying that Malik could marry "anyone" and pulling out "Hema Malini or Sridevi" as candidates. What sent them on the warpath was Malik first denying knowing Siddiqui and then saying that no marriage had taken place.

"In Islam there can be a divorce, only if the *nikah* is valid. I was wrongly made to believe that the pictures of Ayesha sent to me were of the girl I was marrying. I feel terrible about the mess created by a family that has caused

*liye yeh kiya hai* (She has done this to get cheap publicity)." All the world's scorned women could not have had Siddiqui's fury. She said she sought an apology on bended knee and added that Malik could only marry again after completing divorce proceedings.

To the Siddiquis, Malik was an expert in all but cricket. "In enticing girls," Ayesha's father thundered, and warned the Mirzas, "He might have used the same skills to floor Sania that he had used to lure my daughter." The only thing the family of the lured woman wanted was "divorce... but he is not conceding it because it will ex-

consummated the marriage. Not just the evidence, the laws also began to stack up against Malik. He faced the prospect of being booked under Section 493 of the Indian Penal Code, cohabiting with a person promising or under the pretext of marriage. He faced up to 10 years in jail. "Had Shoaib not made the blunder, this situation would not have risen," rued his brother-in-law Imran Zafar Malik. It was he who took the initiative to convince the recalcitrant Shoaib to concede divorce.

For Mirza, this was quite an overdose of recent distress. Two months ago, she had called off her engagement to family friend Sohrab. The July 2009 engagement had been a grand, public affair but was broken off due to "incompatibility". It is believed Sohrab struggled with playing second fiddle to his famous wife-to-be.

Malik and Mirza had known each



(FROM LEFT) MAJOR QADRI, ABID RASOOL KHAN, FARISA SIDDIQUI AND KHALED RASOOL ADDRESS A PRESS CONFERENCE; (BELOW) SANIA MIRZA WITH EX-FIANCÉ SOHRAB MIRZA

## SIDDIQUI MADE AVAILABLE DETAILS OF HER E-MAIL AND MOBILE PHONE CONTACTS, PLUS A STAY, AS A MARRIED COUPLE, AT TAJ RESIDENCY.

great grief to the family of my bride-to-be," argued Malik. He maintained that Ayesha's family pressured him into the marriage and claims he realised that he had been cheated three years after the telephonic *nikah*.

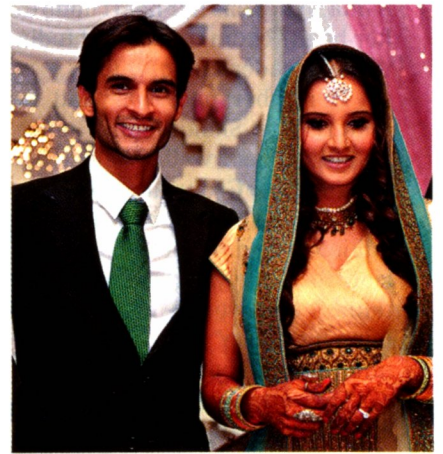
The war was on. After Siddiqui produced a *nikahnama* bearing his signature, Malik kept plodding on thin ice. With Mirza by his side, Malik's interpretation of Siddiqui's motives were simple, "Cheap publicity *lene ke*

pose him as a liar."

The Siddiquis decided to do the exposing themselves. They said there was enough proof to nail Malik, including critical medical evidence. The *nikahnama* issued in Sialkot was not the only information that was going to nail him. Siddiqui made available details of her e-mail and mobile phone contacts, plus a stay, as a married couple, at the Taj Residency (then the Taj Deccan) to contend that the two had

other for several years but the Pakistani turned up in Mirza's life more significantly from November onwards when the two met in Dubai, and later Australia, where she was playing tennis events at the same time the Pakistani team was in town.

The event has also brought into focus the laxity in laws related to the practices followed in Muslim marriages. Jamia Nizamia, Hyderabad's oldest Islamic seminary, issued a



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